

APPEARANCES

8

GOALS

0

Spain won as a collective, but Rodri set its rhythm.

The captain started all eight matches and played 726 minutes without scoring. Yet those numbers barely captured his influence. He completed 692 passes at 94.9 per cent, providing an outlet under pressure and repeatedly putting Spain back on the front foot.

His influence became clearest as the opposition grew stronger. Against France in the semifinal, Rodri screened the defence, disrupted the supply to Michael Olise and Kylian Mbappe, and won 11 duels. His positioning allowed Spain's full-backs and attacking midfielders to advance without surrendering control behind them.

The final summed up his tournament. Spain monopolised possession, attempted 20 shots and prevented Argentina from registering one in normal time. Rodri kept circulating the ball and closing spaces even as the contest became fractious, ensuring Spain never lost the structure that had carried it throughout the tournament.

There was no defining goal or spectacular assist in his highlights. His gift was making the difficult look routine, giving Spain shape in every phase of play. The Golden Ball confirmed what his performances had already shown: the champions' most important player was the one who made everyone around him function better.



GETTY IMAGES

Rodri